

FREE RESOURCE

Counselor Crisis Response Card

For Texas Public School Counselors, K–12 · Step-by-step protocols for when it matters most

● Suicide Ideation / Self-Harm

● Abuse / Neglect Disclosure

● Threat to Others

● Medical / Mental Health Emergency

● Parent in Crisis

📄 Documentation + Texas Reporting Law

🚫 **NEW SB 571: Why Telling Your SRO Isn't Enough**

CLEAR PATH EDUCATION GROUP

1 · SUICIDE IDEATION / SELF-HARM

1. Stay calm. Do NOT leave the student alone.
2. Ask directly: "Are you thinking about hurting yourself?" (Asking does NOT plant the idea.)
3. Assess: Does the student have a plan? Access to means? Timeline?
4. Contact parent/guardian IMMEDIATELY. Document exact words.
5. If imminent danger → Call 911. Otherwise → Refer to LCSW/crisis center.
6. Create a safety plan before the student leaves your office.
7. Follow up within 24 hours. Document everything.

☎ 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline | Crisis Text Line: text HOME to 741741

2 · ABUSE / NEGLECT DISCLOSURE

1. Listen. Do not react with shock or emotion on your face.
2. Say: "Thank you for telling me. This is NOT your fault."
3. Do NOT ask leading questions. Do NOT investigate.
4. Document the student's EXACT words (use quotation marks).
5. Report within 24 hours to DFPS or a law enforcement agency — many districts require BOTH; follow your district policy (TFC §261.101, as amended by SB 571, 2025). Failure to report is a Class A misdemeanor (TFC §261.109).
6. Do NOT tell the parent if the parent is the suspected abuser.
7. Do NOT promise confidentiality. Say: "I have to tell people who can help keep you safe."

⚠ Telling your SRO does NOT satisfy the law. Per TEA's SB 571 guidance, "law enforcement agency" means DPS, municipal police, a county sheriff, or a county constable — it does NOT include a school district police department.

☎ Texas Abuse Hotline (DFPS): 1-800-252-5400 — staffed 24/7

3 · THREAT TO OTHERS

1. Separate the student from potential victims immediately.
2. Notify the principal and SRO (if on campus).
3. Conduct or initiate a threat assessment (use district protocol).
4. Determine: transient threat (expression of frustration) or substantive threat (intent + plan)?
5. Contact parents of BOTH the student making the threat AND the potential victim(s).
6. Document everything: time, exact words, witnesses.
7. Develop a safety plan. May require schedule change, supervision plan, or removal.

 **Follow your district's SB 11 threat assessment team protocol for every threat.**

4 · MEDICAL / MENTAL HEALTH EMERGENCY

1. Call 911 if the student is unconscious, seizing, not breathing, or actively harming self.
2. Call the school nurse. Stay with the student.
3. Clear the area of other students (protect dignity). Do NOT move the student unless there is immediate danger.
4. Contact parent/guardian. Brief responding admin with known medical history.
5. After the event — offer support to witnesses (students AND staff).

5 · PARENT IN CRISIS (AT SCHOOL)

1. Stay calm. Low, steady voice. Do not match their energy. Move to a private space.
2. Verbally threatening → call admin/SRO. You are not required to be yelled at.
3. Emotionally distressed → "I can see how much you care about [child]. Let's work on this together."
4. Domestic violence disclosure → National DV Hotline 1-800-799-7233.
5. Document: date, time, who was present, key statements.

CRISIS DOCUMENTATION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Date and time of disclosure/incident
- ☐ Student's exact words (use quotation marks)
- ☐ Your observations (behavior, affect, physical signs)
- ☐ Who was notified and when (admin, parent, DFPS, police)
- ☐ Actions taken (safety plan, referral, removal from class)
- ☐ Follow-up plan and timeline
- ☐ Signatures (yours + witness if available)

⚠️ Do NOT keep crisis notes in regular counseling files. Maintain a separate locked file.

TEXAS REPORTING REQUIREMENTS

Report deadline	Within 24 hours of first suspicion — TFC §261.101, as amended by SB 571 (2025). The duty is yours personally and cannot be delegated .
Where to report	DFPS (1-800-252-5400) or a law enforcement agency : DPS, municipal police, county sheriff, or county constable. Many district policies require BOTH — follow yours. Per TEA guidance, a school district police department does NOT count — telling your SRO does not discharge the duty.
What counts as abuse	SB 571 expanded abuse to include sexual conduct harmful to a child — including an improper educator-student relationship (Penal Code §21.12) and encouraging a child to engage in sexual conduct.
Failure to report	Class A misdemeanor (TFC §261.109)
Immunity	Good-faith reporters are immune from civil/criminal liability (TFC §261.106)

EMERGENCY NUMBERS

Who	Number	When
911	911	Imminent danger to life
Texas Abuse Hotline (DFPS)	1-800-252-5400	Suspected abuse/neglect
988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	988	Suicide ideation
Crisis Text Line	HOME → 741741	Student prefers text
National DV Hotline	1-800-799-7233	Domestic violence disclosure
Poison Control	1-800-222-1222	Ingestion/substance
Texas School Safety Center	1-877-304-2727	School safety concern